

IIT Madras's reserved seats for athletes: Sea of opportunities

In its **recognition** of the fact that excellence cannot be **confined** to the classroom alone, **the Sports Excellence Admission** (SEA) scheme by IIT-Madras **marks** a transformative step. Launched in July-August 2024, with an investment of around Rs 25 crore and operational only in the Madras campus, 34 **supernumerary** seats are reserved for athletes who have won at least one medal in a national or international event in a sport recognised by federations under the Union sport ministry in the last four years, scored at least 75 per cent in their Class XII board exams and cleared the JEE (Advanced) test. It rewards athletic **prowess** with infrastructural support, as well as the opportunity to **pursue** higher education at one of the country's most **coveted** institutions.

In India, there has traditionally been a **disconnect** between academic dreams and athletic ambitions, with the focus largely being on the former. But sports requires a unique set of skills — discipline, **perseverance**, teamwork, and leadership — that can be equally invaluable in the world of innovation and technology. **Providing** athletes with specialised support **offers** them a chance to **excel** in their chosen sport and academic career. This can create a more **diverse** and rounded educational environment, where success is not **solely** defined by the ability to excel in a single **domain** but by a broader range of skills. These changes are also **aligned with** the global trend of **holistic** education. By **embracing** and supporting athletic excellence, IIT-Madras **sets a precedent** for other educational institutions across the country towards a more **inclusive** definition of achievement.

The **fact** that the origin of the scheme **lies** in tragedy — a series of student suicides on campus between September 2022 and April 2023 — also **points at** the larger **malaise** affecting higher education in India, where the barriers are too many, the opportunities too few and the **stakes** impossibly high. In recent years, IITs have **consciously** tried to **address** the lack of **diversity**, both in terms of gender and **socio-economic** backgrounds, through implementation of a supernumerary quota of 20 per cent for women in their undergraduate engineering programmes and **open-door** policies for aspirants to interact with faculty members, among others. **Creating** a culture of **inclusivity** and support **will** allow for better integration of diverse communities into these institutions and help **dismantle stereotypes** of a **homogenous, masculine STEM ecosystem**. However, it is essential that these measures are **complemented** with other reforms, including mentorship, financial **assistance** for the **marginalised**, and counselling services. A **diverse** IIT campus will **encourage** creativity, collaboration, and critical thinking — the foundation upon which India's technological future should be built.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denote 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

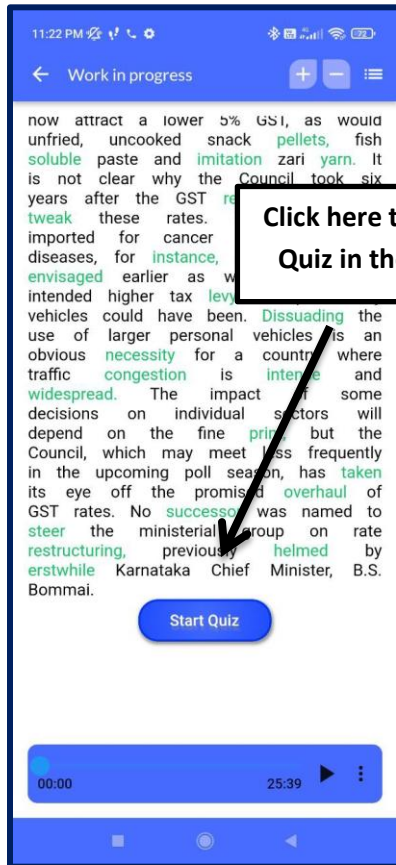
1. **Recognition** (noun) – Acknowledgment, Acceptance, Appreciation, Validation, Approval मान्यता
2. **Confine** (to) (verb) – Restrict, Limit, Bound, Constrain, Enclose सीमित करना
3. **Mark** (verb) – Indicate, Signify, Denote, Highlight, Symbolize दर्शाना
4. **Supernumerary** (noun) – Extra, Surplus, Additional, Excess, Spare अतिरिक्त
5. **Prowess** (noun) – Skill, Expertise, Mastery, Talent, Ability कौशल
6. **Pursue** (verb) – Chase, Follow, Seek, Strive, Track अनुसरण करना
7. **Coveted** (adjective) – Desired, Envied, Sought-after, Prized, Longed-for वांछित
8. **Disconnect** (noun) – Gap, Separation, Division, Break, Detachment अलगाव
9. **Perseverance** (noun) – Persistence, Determination, Tenacity, Endurance, Resolve दृढ़ता
10. **Excel** (verb) – Shine, Outperform, Surpass, Succeed, Thrive उत्कृष्ट होना
11. **Diverse** (adjective) – Varied, Multifaceted, Mixed, Heterogeneous, Assorted विविध
12. **Solely** (adverb) – Exclusively, Only, Purely, Merely, Entirely केवल
13. **Domain** (noun) – Field, Area, Sphere, Realm, Territory क्षेत्र
14. **Align** (with) (verb) – Match, Adjust, Coordinate, Harmonize, Conform मेल खाना
15. **Holistic** (adjective) – Comprehensive, Integrated, Complete, Wholesome, Unified समग्र
16. **Embrace** (verb) – Adopt, Accept, Welcome, Include, Support अपनाना
17. **Set a precedent** (phrase) – Establish a standard, Create a model, Break new ground, Lead the way, Innovate मिसाल कायम करना
18. **Inclusive** (adjective) – Comprehensive, All-embracing, Broad, Wide-ranging, Universal समावेशी
19. **Lie** (verb) – Reside, Exist, Rest, Dwell, Be situated निहित होना
20. **Point at** (phrasal verb) – Indicate, Suggest, Hint, Signal, Direct इशारा करना
21. **Malaise** (noun) – Discomfort, Unease, Unrest, Anxiety, Discontent बेचैनी
22. **Stake** (noun) – Interest, Concern, Investment, Risk, Claim दांव
23. **Consciously** (adverb) – Deliberately, Intentionally, Purposefully, Knowingly, Willfully सचेत रूप से

24. **Diversity** (noun) – Variety, Multifacetedness, Heterogeneity, Range, Multiplicity विविधता
25. **Socio-economic** (adjective) – Social and economic, Class-based, Financial and social, Economic and cultural, Class-related सामाजिक-आर्थिक
26. **Open-door** (adjective) – Accessible, Welcoming, Inclusive, Unrestricted, Free खुला
27. **Inclusivity** (noun) – Inclusiveness, Openness, Acceptance, Diversity, Integration समावेशिता
28. **Dismantle** (verb) – Disassemble, Deconstruct, Break down, Demolish, Destroy खत्म करना
29. **Stereotype** (noun) – Generalization, Cliché, Preconception, Bias, Label रूढ़िवादिता
30. **Homogenous** (adjective) – Uniform, Similar, Alike, Consistent, Unvaried एकरूप
31. **Masculine** (adjective) – Male-dominated, Macho, Manly, Virile, Patriarchal पुरुषप्रधान
32. **STEM** (noun) – Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics, Innovation विज्ञान-प्रौद्योगिकी
33. **Ecosystem** (noun) – Environment, Habitat, Network, Community, System परिसंस्थान
34. **Complement** (verb) – Supplement, Enhance, Complete, Balance, Augment पूरक होना
35. **Assistance** (noun) – Help, Support, Aid, Guidance, Backing सहायता
36. **Marginalised** (adjective) – Excluded, Disadvantaged, Oppressed, Alienated, Neglected हाशिये पर
37. **Diverse** (adjective) – Varied, Multifaceted, Mixed, Heterogeneous, Assorted विविध
38. **Encourage** (verb) – Motivate, Inspire, Support, Boost, Foster प्रोत्साहित करना

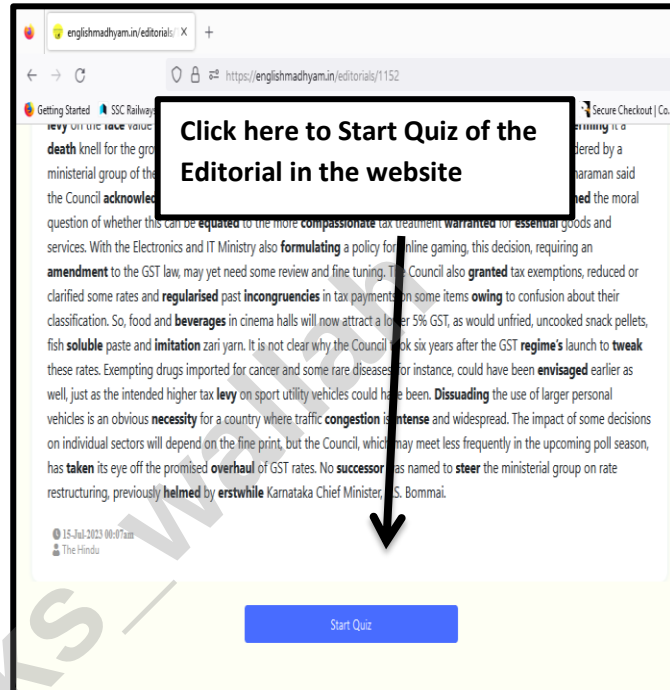
Summary of the Editorial

1. Transformative Initiative: IIT Madras launched the Sports Excellence Admission (SEA) scheme to integrate athletic and academic excellence.
2. Exclusive to Madras Campus: The scheme started in July-August 2024 with a Rs 25 crore investment, currently limited to IIT Madras.
3. Supernumerary Seats: 34 additional seats are reserved for athletes meeting specific academic and sports criteria.
4. Eligibility Criteria: Applicants must have won a medal in a national or international event in the last four years, scored at least 75% in Class XII, and cleared JEE (Advanced).
5. Bridging the Gap: Traditionally, academics and sports were seen as separate, but this initiative acknowledges the value of sports skills in education.
6. Skills Beyond Academics: Athletes bring discipline, perseverance, teamwork, and leadership, which are valuable in innovation and technology.
7. Holistic Education Approach: Aligns with global trends where education values a broad skill set rather than single-domain excellence.
8. Setting a Precedent: IIT Madras's initiative encourages other institutions to adopt similar inclusive policies.
9. Addressing Campus Issues: The scheme partly stems from concerns over student suicides (2022-23), highlighting the need for mental well-being and inclusivity.
10. Diversity Efforts at IITs: IITs have already introduced 20% supernumerary quotas for women and faculty interaction programs to improve inclusivity.
11. Beyond Just Sports Admissions: While this is a step forward, mentorship, financial aid, and mental health support must also be strengthened.
12. Breaking Stereotypes: Encouraging diverse talents challenges the perception of IITs as purely academic and masculine STEM environments.
13. Promoting Creativity & Collaboration: A diverse IIT campus fosters innovation, teamwork, and critical thinking, strengthening India's technological landscape.
14. Greater Opportunities for Athletes: Provides talented sportspersons with a chance to pursue world-class education while continuing their sports careers.
15. Long-term Vision: If implemented effectively, this model can reshape India's higher education system by making it more inclusive, balanced, and holistic.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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